

Austin pulls the plug on automatic license plate readers amid privacy concerns

Council members and advocates hosted a press conference one day after the city manager axed its license plate reader program.

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AUSTIN, Texas — Austin is doing away with its license plate reader program at the end of the month after [mounting concerns over privacy and data collection](#).

Automatic License Plate Readers, or ALPRs, are devices that rapidly snap photos of license plates, then store the images in a database that can link them to potential crimes or missing persons. On Wednesday, some council members and local coalitions addressed how they believe APLRs are being weaponized as mass surveillance tools.

"There is not enough companies out there that can guarantee that our data will be protected," said Annette Price, the executive director of Grassroots Leadership. "It is best to not collect it in the first place."

The city has contracts with Flock Safety and Axon to run the program. The city has 40 cameras installed and roughly 500 mounted on police vehicles.

The arguments made by city leaders is that data collected could be used to track down people seeking abortions and gender-affirming care.

"That's the concern here: the dramatic negative impact on civil liberties and privacy for our community with programs like this," District 7 Councilmember Mike Seigel said.

KVUE reached out to Flock Safety on Wednesday about the concerns and the city's decision to end its contract. In a statement, the company said its technology has provided a public safety benefit to Austin that has resulted in 165 arrests, about 134 prosecutions and one missing/endangered person found.

"Flock has designed our technology with accountability mechanisms built into the system. Every search that is conducted on an agency's cameras is preserved permanently in an audit trail - enabling oversight and transparency for every search. We are committed to ensuring every jurisdiction can use Flock products in a way that reflects their values. Community safety does not need to come at the expense of community values," said Holly Beilin, Flock's director of Communications.

Beilin also noted that Flock doesn't have contracts with Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE) or the Department of Homeland Security. She said how the technology is used and which federal agencies law enforcement collaborates with is entirely up to each police department.

During a city work session Tuesday, City Manager T.C. Broadnax decided to axe the program and withdraw it from Thursday's agenda, when a vote on extending the program was to be considered.

Austin Police Chief Lisa Davis said she understood the concerns voiced by community members, but credited the technology as one that filled the gap with the department's staffing shortage and crime reduction.

"As your Austin Police Department, we can be good stewards of this and do good with it and make some exceptional, exceptional dents in our violent crime and in what it truly takes to make this, Austin, the safest city in America," Davis said on Tuesday.

KVUE reached out to APD on Wednesday for a comment regarding the decision. They provided the following statement on Thursday.

"The Austin Police Department fully supports the City Manager's decision to withdraw the item related to Automatic License Plate Readers (ALPRs). Listening to the concerns raised by our community members and elected officials has given us an important opportunity to pause and reassess the path forward.

This includes increased focus on education, community engagement, active listening, and further research to ensure we are addressing all perspectives. The City of Austin and Austin Police Department deserves access to the most effective technology, tools, and resources to keep our community, and our officers safe.

The use of technology plays a critical role in how cases are solved and removing dangerous criminals from our streets. It is essential for us to responsibly look at ways to expand access to investigative technologies.

I look forward to the continued conversations that will be taking place as we all work together advancing our technology use in a way that aligns with all our values."

It's not clear what will happen to the cameras – whether they will stay installed or be disconnected. Councilmember Vanessa Fuentes said it's a discussion that will need to take place with Broadnax.

Whether the ALPRs will be substituted is another factor Fuentes added that the city would need to look into. The council member pointed to when the council shelved LPR technology back in 2020.

"We'll continue to ensure that we are pursuing justice for, for all victims in our community," Fuentes said.

District 9 Councilmember Zo Qadri noted while ALPRs are axed for now, there is a possibility that the item could be brought back to the council in the next five to six months. However, Qadri believes the city will be able to push back against it when the time comes.

